To Swipe or Not to Swipe: Hamlet’s Dilemma

Chapter One — To Be or Not to Be... Relevant?

Welcome, dear readers, to our irreverent romp through the hallowed halls of Shakespearean tragedy! Today, we're tackling the elephant in the theater - Hamlet, the brooding Danish prince who's been hogging the spotlight for over four centuries. But is he still worthy of all this attention? Let's find out!

Picture, if you will, a world where instead of soliloquizing about the nature of existence, our protagonist is more concerned with his follower count on Instagram. "To post or not to post, that is the question," Hamlet muses, thumb hovering over his smartphone. Suddenly, the play's five-hour runtime doesn't seem so daunting, does it?

Now, I know what you're thinking: "But professor, Hamlet is a timeless masterpiece!" To which I say, so is the art of cave painting, but you don't see us lugging around boulders to doodle on, do you? The truth is, our boy Hamlet might be suffering from a severe case of cultural jetlag.

Let's consider for a moment why today's youth might prefer scrolling through TikTok rather than sitting through yet another production of Hamlet. Is it because their attention spans have been reduced to that of a caffeinated goldfish? Possibly. But more likely, it's because watching someone spin in a circle while lip-syncing to the latest pop hit is infinitely more relatable than watching a prince debate whether or not to kill his uncle.

Imagine if Shakespeare had written Hamlet for the Netflix generation. Episode 1: Hamlet's dad dies. Episode 2: Ghost Dad appears. Episodes 3-8: Hamlet procrastinates. Season finale: Everyone dies. Binge-worthy? Perhaps not. But at least you could watch it at 1.5x speed and get through the whole thing in the afternoon.

But let's be fair to our indecisive prince. Maybe he's not irrelevant; maybe he's just misunderstood. After all, isn't Hamlet's existential crisis the perfect metaphor for trying to decide what to watch on

Netflix? The paralysis of choice, the fear of committing to the wrong option - suddenly, "To be, or not to be" doesn't sound so different from "Stranger Things or The Crown?"

And let's not forget Hamlet's penchant for playacting madness. In today's world, we call that "building a personal brand." If Hamlet were alive today, he'd be that guy on YouTube doing "PRETENDING TO BE CRAZY PRANK (GONE WRONG!) (NEARLY DIED!)" videos. His subscriber count would be through the roof!

But here's where our prince might actually be onto something. In an age of carefully curated social media personas, Hamlet's struggle with authenticity hits surprisingly close to home. "To thine own selfie be true," as the Bard might say if he were alive and desperately trying to stay relevant today.

Speaking of staying relevant, let's talk about Hamlet's famous soliloquies. In a world where the average person's daily communication consists of emojis and abbreviations, Hamlet's lengthy monologues seem about as practical as using a quill and inkwell to send a tweet. Can you imagine if Hamlet tried to express his inner turmoil in the language of today?

"2B or not 2B, that is the????"

"Alas, poor Yorick! I knew him. #ThrowbackThursday"

"Something is rotten in the state of Denmark. #BadVibes #NeedAVacation"

Suddenly, the profound seems a tad... less profound.

But perhaps we're being too harsh on our melancholy Dane. After all, he's dealing with some heavy stuff - murder, betrayal, incest (keep it in the family, right?). These themes are universal, timeless even. But so is the theme of a boy and his dog, and you don't see Old Yeller getting five-hour stage adaptations, do you?

The real question we need to ask ourselves is this: In a world grappling with climate change, political upheaval, and whether or not pineapple belongs on pizza, does Hamlet still have something meaningful to contribute to the conversation? Or is he just that guy at the party who won't stop talking about his gap year in Europe?

Let's be honest, if Hamlet were a modern-day university student, he'd be that philosophy major who corners you at parties to talk about Nietzsche. Sure, it's intellectually stimulating for the first five minutes, but by minute six, you're eyeing the exit and wondering if you can fake a phone call to escape.

But maybe, just maybe, that's exactly why we need Hamlet. In a world of hot takes and instant gratification, perhaps there's value in a story that forces us to slow down, to ponder, to ask the big questions. Even if those questions are delivered in iambic pentameter and come with a body count that would make George R.R. Martin blush.

So, is Hamlet still relevant? Well, that's a question each of us must answer for ourselves. But if you find yourself lying awake at night, paralyzed by indecision, unsure whether to take action or continue to waffle... congratulations! You might just be experiencing your very own Hamlet moment. Just try not to stab anyone hiding behind a curtain, okay?

In conclusion, whether Hamlet is a timeless masterpiece or just really good at marketing himself, one thing's for sure - he's got us all talking. And isn't that the point of great art? To provoke discussion, debate, and the occasional English literature essay?

So the next time someone asks you if Hamlet is still relevant, just remember: To be relevant, or not to be relevant - that is the question. Whether 'tis nobler in the mind to suffer the slings and arrows of outrageous literary criticism, or to take arms against a sea of modern distractions...

On second thought, maybe just tell them to read the SparkNotes. It's what Hamlet would do.

Chapter Two — Madness or Marketing?

Welcome back, intrepid readers! Having survived our journey through Hamlet's questionable relevance, we now turn our discerning eyes to a truly pressing matter: Was Hamlet's "madness" simply the world's first viral marketing campaign? Buckle up, folks – we're about to dive deep into the murky waters of medieval brand management.

Picture, if you will, the Danish court as the ultimate corporate environment. Elsinore isn't just a castle; it's a startup, and Hamlet is its

disgruntled, hoodie-wearing CEO who's just discovered some serious embezzlement in the accounts. What's a prince to do when faced with such a PR nightmare? Why, fake a mental breakdown, of course!

Let's consider the genius of Hamlet's strategy. In one fell swoop (or should we say, one dropped doublet), our prince goes from "that moody guy who wears too much black" to "Denmark's Most Eligible Bachelor: Tortured Artist Edition." Suddenly, he's not just the heir to the throne; he's a brand. Move over, Kanye – Hamlet walked so you could run.

But wait, I hear you cry, surely Hamlet's behavior was genuinely erratic? To which I say: have you been on Twitter lately? In a world where Elon Musk can tank his own stock prices with a single tweet, Hamlet's antics seem positively tame. "Alas, poor Yorick" is practically a masterclass in creating shareable content. If Hamlet were around today, that skull would have its own Instagram account, mark my words.

Now, let's talk about Ophelia. Poor, sweet Ophelia – or as I like to call her, the world's first influencer. Think about it: she's young, beautiful, and has a penchant for flower crowns that would make Coachella attendees weep with envy. Her "madness" isn't a tragic descent into insanity; it's a carefully curated aesthetic. Ophelia walked so cottagecore could run.

Picture Ophelia's social media presence: "Just a Danish girl, living in a Danish world #FlowerPower #RiverVibes #DrowningInStyle." Her tragic end? Simply a way to ensure her legacy. After all, nothing boosts your follower count quite like a mysterious and untimely demise. Ophelia didn't die; she just pivoted to become a full-time ghost influencer.

But let's not forget the true marketing maven of Elsinore: Polonius. This guy understood the power of personal branding before it was cool. "To thine own self be true"? More like "To thine own brand be true." Polonius wasn't just giving advice; he was dropping taglines. If LinkedIn had existed in medieval Denmark, you can bet Polonius would have been posting daily inspirational quotes and humble-bragging about his "servant leadership" style.

Of course, no discussion of Elsinore's PR machine would be complete without mentioning the OG power couple: Claudius and Gertrude.

These two understood the importance of a strong united front. Sure, there might have been a little light treason and fratricide involved, but can we take a moment to appreciate their commitment to the "happily blended family" narrative? It's not murder; it's "conscious uncoupling" taken to its logical extreme.

Now, I know what you're thinking: "But professor, isn't this reading too much into it? Surely Shakespeare wasn't thinking about brand management when he wrote Hamlet!" To which I say: my dear student, have you seen how many plays the man wrote? Shakespeare wasn't just a playwright; he was a content-creation machine. The Globe wasn't a theater; it was the world's first co-working space.

Consider the play-within-a-play. We call it "The Mousetrap," but let's be real – it's basically the medieval equivalent of a subtweet. Hamlet isn't just trying to "catch the conscience of the king"; he's trying to go viral. If he'd had access to TikTok, you can bet that play would have been a three-minute dance routine set to "Murdered Dad Check."

But perhaps the true marketing genius of Hamlet lies not in the characters, but in the play itself. Think about it: Shakespeare took a classic revenge tale and turned it into a five-act meditation on the nature of existence. That's not writing; that's upselling. He promised us a simple "murder the bad guy" story and instead delivered the theatrical equivalent of a philosophy degree. Talk about exceeding customer expectations!

In the end, maybe Hamlet's true madness lies not in his behavior, but in his refusal to fully commit to his personal brand. One minute he's the grief-stricken son, the next he's the cold-hearted killer. Make up your mind, Hamlet! In the cutthroat world of court politics, a consistent brand message is key.

So, the next time you find yourself watching Hamlet and wondering why he doesn't just get on with it and stab Claudius already, remember: it's not about the destination, it's about the journey. Or more accurately, it's about the content you create along the way. After all, what's the point of revenge if you can't get a few good soliloquies out of it?

In conclusion, was Hamlet mad? Was he a marketing genius? Or was he simply a man desperately in need of a good PR team? Perhaps, like all great brands, the answer lies in the eye of the beholder. One thing's

for sure: in the Game of thrones, you either win, or you die... but if you're Hamlet, you do both, and somehow still end up as the face of sophomore English classes for centuries to come.

Now that's what I call a legacy brand.

Chapter Three — Hamletonomics: The Revenge Economy

Welcome back, esteemed scholars of Shakespearean shenanigans! It's time to don our economist hats (I suggest a jaunty tricorn) and dive into the fascinating world of Hamletonomics. Yes, that's right - we're about to explore how one prince's existential crisis became Denmark's economic boom. Who knew revenge could be so profitable?

Let's start with the basics: Hamlet's father is dead, his uncle is king, and Denmark's GDP is about to go through the roof. How, you ask? Simple: revenge is a growth industry.

First, consider the arms race. Hamlet's sudden interest in fencing isn't just a hobby - it's stimulating the local economy. Think of all the swords, daggers, and conveniently placed goblets of poison that need to be manufactured. Laertes alone probably kept an entire blacksmith's guild in business with his demand for ever-sharper rapiers. It's the medieval equivalent of the military-industrial complex, and business is booming!

But the economic impact doesn't stop there. Hamlet's "antic disposition" creates a whole new sector of the job market: royal surveillance. Suddenly, everyone from Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to poor Ophelia is employed in the burgeoning field of Hamlet-watching. It's like a 24/7 reality show but with more soliloquies and fewer hot tubs.

Speaking of Ophelia, let's not overlook the flourishing flower industry. Her penchant for distributing symbolic blooms must have been a boon for local florists. "Rosemary for remembrance" isn't just a poetic line - it's a savvy marketing slogan. If Ophelia had lived in our time, she'd be an Instagram influencer partnering with FTD: "Use code MADNESS for 20% off your next bouquet!"

Now, let's talk about the real estate market in Elsinore. With all the eavesdropping going on, there must have been a sudden demand for

houses with thicker walls and fewer conveniently placed curtains. And let's not forget the castle's ever-growing need for more secret passages. That's job creation right there - the "Sneaky Carpenter" guild must have been working overtime!

But the true economic genius of Hamlet lies in his creation of the world's first ghost-based economy. Think about it: without Old Hamlet's spirit, there'd be no play, no revenge, and certainly no economic boom. It's an ectoplasmic stimulus at its finest! Perhaps Hamlet wasn't procrastinating after all - he was simply allowing time for the multiplier effect to kick in.

Let's not overlook the entertainment sector. Hamlet's play-within-a-play isn't just a clever ruse - it's a job creator. Think of all the actors employed, the set designers commissioned, and the costumers contracted. Hamlet single-handedly revived Danish theater! Move over, Broadway - Elsinore is the new cultural capital.

And what about the grave-digging industry? Thanks to Hamlet's existential musings (and his rather cavalier attitude towards human life), the grave-digging business is booming. It's a growth market with a captive customer base - talk about job security!

Of course, we can't discuss Hamletonomics without mentioning the booming poison trade. From ears to sword tips to wine goblets, the demand for deadly concoctions is through the roof. It's enough to make Walter White jealous. Breaking Bad? More like Breaking Denmark!

But perhaps the most brilliant economic move in the entire play is Hamlet's decision to send Rosencrantz and Guildenstern to England. It's not just a plot device - it's international diplomacy and trade relations all rolled into one. Hamlet: prince, philosopher, and pioneer of Brexit negotiations.

Now, I know what you're thinking: "But professor, doesn't everyone die at the end? How is that good for the economy?" Ah, but you're forgetting the lucrative funeral industry! Not to mention the boom in the "conquering Norwegian prince" sector. Fortinbras isn't just taking over Denmark - he's stimulating its economy with a hostile takeover. It's trickle-down economics, medieval style!

In conclusion, Hamlet isn't just a tragedy - it's a masterclass in economic stimulation through revenge-based spending. The real tragedy is that Hamlet didn't live long enough to see the fruits of his

labor. He could have traded in his "To be or not to be" for "To buy or not to buy" and become Denmark's first philosopher-economist.

So the next time someone tells you that an English degree isn't practical, just remind them of the economic powerhouse that is Hamlet. After all, in the words of the Bard himself, "There is nothing either good or bad, but thinking makes it so." And if you think hard enough, you can turn even the gloomiest Danish prince into an economic visionary.

Now, if you'll excuse me, I'm off to invest in the up-and-coming "alas, poor Yorick" skull replica market. I hear it's going to be huge in Denmark this quarter.

Chapter Four — Hamlet 2.0: The Upgrade Tragedy Needed

Ladies, gentlemen, and non-binary courtiers welcome to the final act of our Shakespearean satire! It's time to drag Hamlet kicking and screaming into the 21st century. Buckle up, buttercups - we're about to give the melancholy Dane a much-needed digital makeover.

Imagine, if you will, a world where Hamlet's "To be or not to be" speech is delivered not to an empty stage, but to his YouTube subscribers. "What's up, Danes? It's ya boy, HamletPrince99, back with another existential crisis video. Don't forget to like, comment, and subscribe... to this mortal coil."

In Hamlet 2.0, our prince doesn't need to hire a troupe of actors to catch the conscience of the king. No, sir! He simply slides into Claudius's DMs with a carefully curated selection of "You vs. The Guy She Told You Not to Worry About" memes featuring Old Hamlet and Claudius. Checkmate, uncle-dad.

But why stop there? Let's reimagine the entire cast for the social media age. Ophelia becomes an ASMR YouTuber specializing in underwater flower arrangement. Polonius is that guy who comments "First!" on every video, and then proceeds to give unsolicited advice in paragraph form. And Rosencrantz and Guildenstern? They're identical twin TikTok stars who nobody can tell apart, famous for their "Is This Treason?" prank series.

Now, let's talk about the ghost of Hamlet's father. In our upgraded

version, he doesn't need to walk the ramparts - he simply haunts Hamlet's Twitter mentions. "uR until killed me. Avenge me. #RevengeGoals #ThrowbackThursday" Suddenly, Hamlet's hesitation makes a lot more sense. After all, how can you trust a ghost who doesn't even use proper grammar?

But the real game-changer in Hamlet 2.0 is the introduction of smartphones. Suddenly, all of Hamlet's problems have app-based solutions. Feeling indecisive? There's an app for that. Need to determine if your uncle is a murderer? There's an app for that too. Want to stage a coup without all the messy sword-fighting? You guessed it - there's an app for that.

Picture this: instead of a lengthy soliloquy, Hamlet simply opens his "To Be or Not To Be" decision-making app. It asks him a series of questions:

1. Are you currently a prince?

2. Has your uncle recently married your mother?

3. On a scale of 1 to 10, how ghostly was your last paternal interaction?

Based on his answers, the app generates a custom action plan, complete with a revenge timeline and suggested hashtags for maximum social media impact.

Of course, we can't forget the play-within-a-play scene. In Hamlet 2.0, it's not a theatrical production - it's a viral TikTok challenge. The "Catch the Conscience of the King Challenge" spreads through Elsinore faster than you can say "Something is rotten in the state of Denmark." Claudius's guilty reaction? Captured in 4K and trending worldwide within minutes.

But perhaps the most revolutionary aspect of Hamlet 2.0 is its integration with the gig economy. Why rely on a single gravedigger when you can use "Digr" - the app that connects you with local, freelance grave-digging professionals? Need someone to carry your messages to Norway? Skip the hassle and use "Messengr" - it's like Uber but for international diplomacy.

And let's not forget about Hamlet's famous indecisiveness. In our upgraded version, he doesn't need to spend five acts waffling - he just creates a poll on his Instagram stories. "Should I kill Claudius? Swipe

up to vote!" Democracy in action, folks.

Of course, no modern reimagining would be complete without a foray into space. Imagine "Hamlet: The Final Frontier" - where something is rotten in the state of the Galactic Empire. Hamlet is a young Jedi, torn between avenging his father and staying true to the light side of the Force. Claudius? He's gone full Sith Lord. And the ghost of Old Hamlet? A Force hologram, obviously. "Luke, I am your father" has nothing on "Hamlet, I was murdered by my brother."

But perhaps the most crucial upgrade in Hamlet 2.0 is the introduction of a good therapist. Imagine how quickly we could wrap this whole tragedy up if Hamlet had access to quality mental health care. "Doctor, I keep seeing my dead father." "Interesting. Have you considered that this might be related to unresolved grief rather than a call to violent revenge?" Boom. Five acts were condensed into a 50-minute session, co-pay included.

In the end, the true tragedy of Hamlet isn't the bloodbath finale - it's the missed opportunity for a killer app. Think about it: an all-in-one platform for revenge plotting, soliloquy practice, and ethical dilemma resolution. We could call it "DaneTech" or "Elsinore Valley." Forget "To be or not to be" - the real question is "To IPO or not to IPO."

So there you have it, folks - Hamlet for the digital age. A world where soliloquies become viral videos, where poison is replaced by cybercrime, and where "Alas, poor Yorick" becomes a popular Instagram filter. Is it an improvement on the original? Well, that's for you to decide. But one thing's for sure - in Hamlet 2.0, the play's no longer the thing. The app's the thing wherein we'll catch the conscience of the king.

And on that note, I'll leave you with this final thought: in a world of constant upgrades and updates, perhaps the true wisdom lies in Hamlet's words: "There are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio, than are dreamt of in your philosophy." Or your smartphone's operating system, for that matter.

Class dismissed. Don't forget to like and subscribe to the Danish royal family's YouTube channel on your way out!

Conclusion

As we close the curtain on our irreverent journey through a digitized Elsinore, it's worth taking a moment to reflect on the broader implications of our playful reimagining. While our digital Hamlet, with his smartphone soliloquies and viral vendettas, may seem a far cry from Shakespeare's original creation, this exercise in modernization touches upon a very real and pressing issue in our contemporary world: the growing disconnect between classical literature and the digital native generation.

The art of the written word, as exemplified by Shakespeare's masterful prose and poetry, represents a pinnacle of human expression and cultural achievement. Works like "Hamlet" have endured for centuries precisely because they speak to universal human experiences and emotions. However, in an age of 280-character limits and fleeting attention spans, these dense, nuanced texts can seem increasingly inaccessible to younger readers.

The challenge we face is not a lack of relevance in classical works, but rather a shift in the way information is consumed and processed in the digital age. Today's youth, accustomed to the rapid-fire pace of social media and the instant gratification of digital content, may struggle to engage with the slower, more contemplative rhythm of classical literature.

Yet, the themes explored in works like "Hamlet" - identity, morality, power, and the human condition - are perhaps more relevant than ever in our hyperconnected world. The question then becomes: How do we bridge this gap? How do we make the richness of classical literature accessible and appealing to a generation raised on memes and social media?

Our humorous modernization of "Hamlet" offers one potential approach. By recasting timeless themes in a contemporary context, we create points of connection between the classical and the modern. This is not about dumbing down or diminishing great works, but rather about creating new entry points that resonate with contemporary experiences.

Humor, in particular, can be a powerful tool in this endeavor. It disarms, it engages, and it makes the unfamiliar feel approachable. By laughing at a meme-ified Hamlet or a LinkedIn-obsessed Polonius,

we're not mocking Shakespeare, but rather celebrating the enduring relevance of his characters and themes.

Moreover, this approach encourages critical thinking and media literacy. In drawing parallels between Hamlet's soliloquies and social media posts, or between court intrigues and online drama, we invite readers to consider both the timeless aspects of human nature and the specific ways our digital age shapes our experiences and expressions of these universal themes.

Of course, modernizing classics through humor is not a substitute for engaging with the original texts. Rather, it should serve as a gateway, piquing curiosity and fostering a sense of connection that encourages deeper exploration. The goal is not to replace Shakespeare with memes but to use memes as a bridge to Shakespeare.

As we navigate the challenges of preserving cultural literacy in the digital age, we must remain open to innovative approaches that speak to new generations. Whether through humorous modernizations, digital adaptations, or interactive experiences, the key is to maintain the essence of these timeless works while presenting them in ways that resonate with contemporary audiences.

In conclusion, our journey with digital Hamlet reminds us that great art is not static, but alive and ever-evolving. Just as Shakespeare borrowed from and reimagined the stories of his time, we too can reinterpret and reinvigorate classical works for our era. By doing so, we not only make these works more accessible but also enrich our understanding of both the past and the present.

As we scroll, swipe, and share our way through the 21st century, let us not forget the power of words, the depth of human experience, and the timeless relevance of great literature. For in the end, whether expressed through a heart-wrenching soliloquy or a carefully crafted tweet, the fundamental questions of existence remain the same. To engage or not to engage with classical literature in the digital age - that is the question. And hopefully, through approaches that blend the classical with the contemporary, more and more readers will choose to engage.